

An Examination of The Role of a Pastor

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Introduction

What is the role of a pastor? Is he to make the church bigger? Is he to lead? I believe, to succinctly put it, the role of a pastor is to save souls and to shepherd those whose souls have been saved.

Another way to look at the problem is to ask: what is the role of Satan, the enemy? He wants to send souls to Hell, and destroy lives. Thus, it is clear, that the Pastor's role must be to frustrate Satan's plans by sending people to Heaven and making lives better and more holy.

The Pastor is to nurture, encourage, and build up the church. And he must do this by being strong himself, with the Word and prayer, and with fellowship with the church.

In my first source¹ written by Percy, there is the analysis of leadership and ministry. It says, “St Paul would probably not have been shortlisted. He was definitely not the kind of minister the Corinthians were looking for. Yet he was exactly what they needed.”

What this is saying is that a leader of the church will not look like the typical leader that people expect. Paul the Apostle was possibly bald and short and had nothing attractive about him. He was also educated by the Greeks rather than being primarily a Jew.

The Bible says that at times, he had no good speech and was timid. People accused him of being strong in his letters, but weak in person.

Essentially, what Percy is trying to say is that leading a church is different from leading a business. This is exactly what John MacArthur,² in his book, *The Book on Leadership*, says about a leader of the church. John MacArthur quotes Jesus, who said, “You know that the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, and those who are great exercise authority over them. Yet it shall not be so among you” (Matthew 20).

MacArthur then says, “According to Christ, then, the truest kind of leadership demands service, sacrifice, and selflessness” (v).

Richie,³ in the third source, says, “Pastoral leadership is an integration of theology, spirituality, and ministry incorporating all pastoral roles and functions.” What I believe Richie is saying is that a pastor will have to use all sorts of methods, and all his wisdom and experience in

¹ Percy, Martyn. “Leadership and Ministry.” *Theology* 120, no. 4 (2017): 279–81. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0040571x17698422>.

² MacArthur, John F. *The Book on Leadership: A Guide to Discovering the Characteristics of a True Leader Based on the Ministry of the Apostle Paul*. Nashville: T. Nelson Publishers, 2004.

³ Richie, Tony Lee. *Perceptions of Pastoral Leadership Principles and Practices within the Church of God (Cleveland, TN)*. DMin diss., Regent University, 2000.

order to lead a church. The role of a pastor is a theologian, counselor, shepherd, and janitor. The pastor has to do all sorts of things for the congregation, for the church, and for God.

The Pastor has to play politics and serve God at the same time. He has to make relations with the community in the city, and has to be friends of prostitutes. He has to be friendly to all these bad people, but maintain his integrity and the purity of himself and the church.

It is a dangerous business that is the role of a pastor. It is very difficult. It is so easy to burn out and to get dangerously tainted by the world and by the congregation.

The congregation will always point out flaws in the Pastor and claw at the pastor to be a better person for their needs. And the Pastor needs to submit to the congregation and do their bidding. He must be a servant.

The congregation lives in the world, and will bring worldly things into the church, such as worldly money.

According to Alistair Begg,⁴ in his book, *On Being a Pastor*, he says, “God always gives a clear call to those whom He has chosen for the ministry, so that when that call comes they can do nothing other than respond to it. They will not be able to say no to it.”

He then says, “Our Lord’s words about the importance of a man not looking back once he has put his hand to the plow have particular relevance to pastors and teachers.”

What Begg is saying is that we need to be serious about the call of being a pastor. When we are called, it is a mandatory calling, and God will equip us to accomplish the task.

⁴ Prime, Derek J., and Alistair Begg. *On Being a Pastor: Understanding Our Calling and Work*. Chicago: Moody Press, 2004.

The call of being a pastor is not a joke - essentially, it is giving up your life. The pastor has to sacrifice his life for the sheep. This is what Jesus Christ did when he sacrificed his life on the cross.

And when we are called, we cannot look back after we put our hand to the plow. That is how serious the call is. It means that we are ready to give up our lives when we dedicate our lives to the pastorate. And this includes simply being a Christian as well.

And what is the actual role of a pastor? What does he do?

This is what I want to focus on now; and to answer it simply, he is a minister of Christ.

What does it mean to be a minister of Christ? I am not an expert on language, but I would like to suggest that it means he administers Christ to all things. He uses baptism to make Christ enter into a person's spirit. He preaches a sermon to deliver Christ to people's minds and spirits. He worships and praises God with music, so that their souls are lifted and receive Christ. And he counsels people, so that Christ can heal people's souls.

More than being a pastor, the pastor is a Christian, first and foremost. He is not just a pastor, he is more so a Christian. And as a Christian, he is a minister of Christ.

But what does pastor literally mean? It means "shepherd," a person who takes care of sheep.

Jesus said three times to Peter, "Feed my sheep." And so, the pastor must take care of the sheep and feed them.

This includes counseling them, loving them, preaching to them, visiting their houses, visiting them in the prisons and hospitals, taking care of their families, loving them, helping them through trauma, teaching them the word of God, and more. You see, Christ was a shepherd, and

so the pastor is like Christ on earth. Because Christ is invisible and too far away and impersonal at times, we need nearby Christians who can warm our hearts and be there for us. And so, the pastor provides fellowship with us.

And so, the Pastor is like us, in that he is one of us, such that he fellowships *with* us, not just for us. And so the role of a pastor is to take care of himself as well.

The Pastor is one of us. He needs to eat meals together, and he needs to survive. He takes care of his family, and needs to make money for the church.

We're all in the same battle and spiritual war together.

You see, the Pastor needs to focus on himself. He is the crux and core of the church. If Satan can take him out - then the church is gone.

And so, what must the Pastor do to sustain himself?

He must read the Word, and be saturated with Christ. He must serve Christ from the heart.

And this is important - if he serves Christ from another motive, other than Christ and love, it will become a false church and a false ministry.

You see, Satan doesn't care about business or work that doesn't improve the Kingdom of God - it has no effect on his Kingdom of Darkness.

It is when the Pastor and the church move in-sync with Christ, and when the Kingdom of God moves and starts going on the offensive that Satan begins to care.

And, as you can see, we have an enemy: Satan. Satan will always attack us and strive to destroy the Pastor's ministry. Thus, he must be all the more aware and vigilant - a term used often in the Bible.

When the Kingdom of God begins making advances, Satan is attacked and his dominion is decreased.

What is Satan's goal? To send people to hell. To make lives miserable. To produce sin.

He wants to "kill, steal, and destroy."

Therefore, the Pastor must be on-guard, and counter these three things that the devil wants.

The pastor has to, instead: save people, make lives better, and reduce sin and produce holiness.

When people are saved, Christ is pleased, and the victory is won. The devil loses the battle for that soul, and the soul goes to heaven forever.

This is the essence of church and the pastor. That is his role.

Why does the pastor preach or do baptism or do church services or do any ministry? It is to save souls. This is the simplest answer.

"Make disciples of all nations," Jesus said as the Great Commission - and so we must.

Conclusion

The main objective of the pastor is to save souls. This is the role of a pastor. This is the main attack on Satan because Satan's main goal is to bring people to hell. That was his main objective.

Hell is death, and death was caused by the fruit of knowledge. We must not forget about Hell, and the danger of eternal separation. It is this battle we are fighting, not just church growth.

The Pastor will be attacked in many different ways because he is doing the work of God, and so he must be equipped with the Word of God and with prayer and with the support of his church. If he is brought down, everyone is susceptible to fall.

Thus, the role of the Pastor is to shepherd the church and to have it flourish and grow. To encourage and build up, as Apostle Paul says. He need to nurture the plant, and have it take root and grow into a big tree.

The church is the main defense and offense of the Kingdom of God, and the role of the pastor is to shepherd it.

Appendix: Book Report

The commentary by Mounce was especially enlightening. I found it fascinating that it was dedicated to Greek words and vocabulary analysis. It was a very precise and accurate way of discerning the text, and I thought that he did a very good job.

It was, however, very long, and to get to the interesting parts that I wanted to read, I had to go through many parts that seemed overly academic and not relevant to ministry or real life.

The book, *Entrusted with the Gospel*, was much more accessible to read. It read like a regular book, rather than a commentary. It was easy to read and was just explaining things in simple language.

Therefore, there were chapters like, “The Sovereign Savior,” which were like treatises on the books of 1 and 2 Timothy, in a way to explain and interpret the texts so that we can see a certain theme in the text.

Also, for my assignments for Faith Seminary, I used the resource written by Alistair Beggs, who wrote a book for pastors. This book allowed me to see that Pastors have a unique role in this society, and their calling is not one of man, but of God.

An example of a call of God is Isaiah in Chapter 6, who cries out, “Send me!”

I believe God is looking at society and the world right now and saying, “My people are hungry and are lacking knowledge. Who shall I send to teach them?”

And the people who are called by God and moved by Him should cry out, “Send me!”

I realized that I would like to be called by God because I am moved by Him, but I still am thinking of being a professor; however, I believe that my time is coming for me to teach and preach and disciple people.

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